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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The 1906 San Francisco Earthquake was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history. It struck early on April 18, 1906, with an estimated magnitude of about 7.9 along the San Andreas Fault.

What happened

- The earthquake violently shook San Francisco for about a minute.
- Buildings collapsed across the city, especially those not built to withstand seismic forces.
- Ruptures along the fault stretched roughly 300 miles.
- Water mains broke, crippling firefighting efforts.

The fires

- Fires broke out almost immediately and burned for three days.
- With limited water supply, the city couldn't control the flames.
- These fires destroyed more of the city than the quake itself—about 80% of San Francisco was devastated.

Human impact

- Around 3,000 people died (estimates vary).
- Over 200,000 residents—more than half the population—were left homeless.
- Refugee camps were set up across the city, including in parks.

Factors that shaped today's San Francisco

1. Earthquake-resistant building practices

The disaster led to major advances in engineering and stricter building codes. Modern San Francisco structures are designed to better withstand seismic activity.

2. Urban redesign and rebuilding

- The city was rebuilt quickly, but not radically redesigned.
- However, infrastructure improvements (wider streets, better materials) were incorporated.
- Downtown and neighborhoods like Market Street became more structurally resilient.

3. Fire safety and infrastructure

- Improved water systems, including auxiliary firewater systems, were developed.
- Fire departments were modernized to handle large-scale emergencies.

4. Population shifts and regional growth

- Many displaced residents relocated temporarily or permanently to nearby areas like Oakland and across the Bay.
- This helped accelerate development in the broader Bay Area.

5. Awareness of seismic risk

The quake fundamentally changed how Californians understand and prepare for earthquakes, influencing policy, insurance, and emergency planning statewide.

Bottom line

The 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy San Francisco—it reshaped how the city (and much of California) builds, plans, and prepares for natural disasters. Its legacy is still visible today in the city's infrastructure, architecture, and regional development.

If you want, I can compare it to more recent earthquakes (like 1989) to show how those lessons held up.

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